RESEARCH DESIGN

Definitions

Following the definition provided by Miller and Demir (2007), "policy community" in this chapter means a special type of interconnected social formation between policy actors, sharing the same policy objective, wherein communication and influence may flow in non-hierarchical patterns. The "centre of policy community" means the core group formed within such a community, and is considered as the heart of the policy community. A "piecemeal approach" denotes a coping strategy employed by the core group of the policy community in dealing with issues incrementally, with one problem and one goal at one time.

Research strategy

How do we assess the role of the technical team as the centre of a new peace policy community? How do we analyse the influence of the peace technical team and its piecemeal approach in sustaining the peace process under constraints? In order to examine the characteristics of the peace technical team as the centre of a peace policy community, we must first observe its institutional trajectory and characteristics. Next, we need to analyse the coping strategy employed for the peace process. For this chapter, the patterns of its negotiation approaches were observed in terms of "vision" and "practice" on peace policy, which can shape and redefine the entire process. Evidence throwing light on the negotiation approach by the peace technical team is presented through two significant cases: (i) federal vision as formally binding; and (ii) facilitation of ethnic summits as informally binding.[1]

To appreciate the implications of the evidence concerning why the piecemeal approach has helped sustain the peace process, this chapter adopts a causal observation process (Brady and Collier 2010). Particular attention is given to short-run problems with short-run feedback (Miller and Friesen 1982). The chapter draws on three types of evidence, namely: (i) in-depth and focused interviews; (ii) reports and personal notes; and (iii) published information. It covers the period June 2011 until December 2015, three months prior to the end of the tenure of the Thein Sein administration.